During one of his meditative sojourns Tishyarakshita is consumed by a burning desire for this handsome prince. Finding him alone, she embraces him and declares: ‘I get a burning feeling inside as though a forest fire were consuming a dry wood.’[8] Kunala says she is akin to his mother and spurns her ‘nondharmic’ advance, whereupon she tells him he is not destined to last much longer. When Taxila rises in rebellion, Kunala is sent to quell it. In the meantime Ashoka is struck by a virulent ailment: ‘excrement began to come out of his mouth, and an impure substance oozed out of all his pores.’[9] No doctors can cure him and made desperate by the thought of his impending end Ashoka expresses a desire to get Kunala to return and succeed him on the throne. Tishyarakshita, fearful of the consequences to her life if this transpires, is now determined to cure the emperor. She first asks Ashoka to forbid all doctors from tending to him. She next instructs his doctors to bring anyone suffering from the same disease to her; in fact, her *modus operandi* in finding a cure for Ashoka is the most compelling part of this tale:

> Tisyaraksita said to the doctors: ‘If any man or woman should come to you suffering from a disease similar to that of the king, I would like to see him immediately.’
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> Before long, it happened that a certain Abhira man was stricken with just such a disease. His wife went to see a doctor and described the illness to him. ‘Bring him in’, said the doctor, ‘I will examine him and then prescribe some medicine.’ However, as soon as the Abhira was brought to him, he took him straight to Tisyaraksita. She, in secret, had him killed, and when he was dead, she split open his belly and examined the stomach. She found inside it a large worm; when it moved, excrement would ooze out of the man’s mouth, and when it went down, it would flow out down below.
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> The queen then ground some peppercorns and gave them to the worm, but he did not die. She tried long peppers and ginger, but again with no success. Finally, she gave some onion to the worm; immediately it died and passed through the intestinal tract.
>
> She then went to Asoka and prescribed this treatment. ‘My lord, eat an onion and you will recover.’